

Challenging menstrual taboos in rural India

Cultural **taboos** and lack of awareness **often confine** girls and women to their homes, keeping them away from school, kitchens and religious spaces

In India, approximately 335 million women experience menstruation but the majority of them are uncomfortable about speaking about it or discussing their menstrual hygiene problems.

Parents, especially in rural areas **are** often **ignorant** and unprepared to discuss this subject with their **adolescent** daughters. However, an ongoing **campaign** called 'Red Achcha Hai' (Red is Good) running in three states **is** breaking the silence around menstruation and **debunking** taboos and restrictions that confine girls and women to their homes and **bar** them from attending school, entering the kitchen and participating in cultural and religious events.

First started in 2018 as a programme to make women and **adolescents** in rural areas in Gujarat **aware** of body **literacy**, **fertility** and menstrual hygiene by CHETNA, a not-for-profit working on nutrition, health and women's **empowerment**, it acquired a new **urgency** in 2020 when newspapers **headlined** the shocking story of how **girls** in a college hostel, supported by a religious trust, **were** asked to **strip** by the college authorities for breaking the hostel's rules for menstruating girls.

This made CHETNA realise that they needed to **accelerate** and **escalate** their efforts. Thus, the Red Achcha Hai campaign Started with a new **vigour** first in rural areas of Gujarat, and Rajasthan and later in Madhya Pradesh, the eye-catching Red Achcha Hai campaign **tapped** the power of drama and visual communication with the CHETNA team dressed in red explaining the menstrual process, the need for menstrual hygiene and breaking **myths** and taboos around menstruation.

The positive **impact** of this awareness programme and distribution of 2199 menstrual hygiene management (MHM) kits containing three information booklets, a clothes brush, a nail cutter and a rope to dry the washed cloth, **led to** its continuation in 47 schools of Sansad block of Ahmedabad since February 2024. Even while focusing on adolescents, the campaign continued to **reach out** to women too.

In 2023, when the campaign was being conducted across 16 villages of Jhagadia block, Bharuch district of Gujarat, a woman sarpanch was invited as a chief guest for an event to celebrate nutrition week organised on the grounds of an **adjoining** temple.

The sarpanch expressed her **reservations** as it was the fourth day of her period. However, after some discussions on the myths surrounding menstruation, the CHETNA team motivated her to come to the function. The sarpanch not only came for the function and sat on the temple steps but entered the temple.

This act made her an icon for breaking the myths and taboos surrounding menstruation and helped to inspire other women **shackled** by **societal barriers imposed** by their families during their menstrual

cycle. A **mother** of a **malnourished** child, who was also one of the participants, **was** menstruating on the day of the function and was **reluctant** to attend. However, when she was informed that the **sarpanch**, who was also menstruating, **had** entered the temple, she took courage and followed her.

The sarpanch's actions challenged traditional taboos and set a powerful example. It highlighted the power of education and support in **overcoming** menstrual **stigma**. The campaign has reached more than 10,000 women and girls and many young people are coming forward to support the campaign.

The **students** of Riverside School of Ahmedabad City **supported** the campaign by raising funds for the initiative to end discrimination against women and girls. Poor menstrual hygiene practices may lead to **recurring** reproductive tract infections which may increase the risk of cervical cancer. The 'Red Achcha Hai' campaign is changing mindsets and **empowering** women and girls to break free from restrictive cultural norms.

[Practice Exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

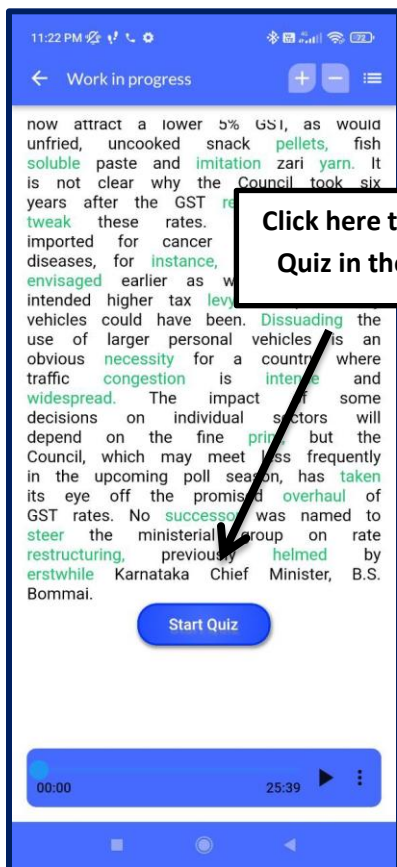
1. **Taboos** (noun) – Prohibition, restriction, ban, constraint, limitation निषेध
2. **Often** (adverb) – Frequently, repeatedly, regularly, commonly, habitually अक्सर
3. **Confine** (verb) – Restrict, imprison, enclose, limit, constrain सीमित करना
4. **Ignorant** (adjective) – Unaware, uninformed, uneducated, clueless, oblivious अनभिज्ञ
5. **Adolescent** (adjective) – Teenage, youthful, juvenile, pubescent, growing युवा
6. **Debunk** (verb) – Expose, disprove, refute, invalidate, demystify खंडन करना
7. **Bar** (verb) – Prohibit, restrict, forbid, ban, exclude रोकना
8. **Literacy** (noun) – Education, knowledge, learning, awareness, proficiency ज्ञान
9. **Fertility** (noun) – Reproductivity, fecundity, fruitfulness, productivity, potency प्रजनन क्षमता
10. **Empowerment** (noun) – Enablement, authorization, strength, confidence, self-sufficiency सशक्तिकरण
11. **Urgency** (noun) – Importance, immediacy, necessity, pressure, exigency तत्कालता
12. **Headline** (verb) – Feature, highlight, announce, report, publicize प्रमुखता से दिखाना
13. **Strip** (verb) – Undress, remove, take off, peel, dismantle हटाना
14. **Accelerate** (verb) – Speed up, hasten, quicken, advance, boost गति बढ़ाना
15. **Escalate** (verb) – Intensify, increase, heighten, amplify, expand बढ़ाना
16. **Vigour** (noun) – Energy, strength, enthusiasm, dynamism, vitality उत्साह
17. **Tap** (verb) – Utilize, exploit, harness, access, draw upon लाभ उठाना
18. **Myth** (noun) – Misconception, false belief, fable, legend, superstition मिथक
19. **Lead** (to) (verb) – Result in, cause, bring about, give rise to, provoke का कारण बनना
20. **Reach out** (phrasal verb) – Connect, extend help, communicate, approach, engage संपर्क करना
21. **Adjoining** (adjective) – Adjacent, neighboring, connected, bordering, beside सटा हुआ
22. **Reservation** (noun) – Doubt, hesitation, concern, apprehension, reluctance संशय, संकोच

23. **Shackle** (verb) – Restrain, bind, hinder, restrict, confine जकड़ना, रोकना
24. **Societal** (adjective) – Social, communal, collective, cultural, public सामाजिक
25. **Barrier** (noun) – Obstacle, hurdle, restriction, blockade, impediment रुकावट, बाधा
26. **Impose** (verb) – Enforce, implement, dictate, mandate, compel थोपना
27. **Malnourished** (adjective) – Undernourished, weak, underfed, starving, emaciated कुपोषित
28. **Reluctant** (to) (adjective) – Hesitant, unwilling, resistant, disinclined, uncertain अनिच्छुक
29. **Overcome** (verb) – Defeat, conquer, prevail over, surmount, rise above काबू पाना
30. **Stigma** (noun) – Shame, disgrace, dishonor, social disapproval, negative perception कलंक, बदनामी
31. **Recurring** (adjective) – Repetitive, frequent, chronic, persistent, continual बार-बार होने वाला
32. **Empower** (verb) – Enable, authorize, strengthen, equip, embolden सशक्त बनाना

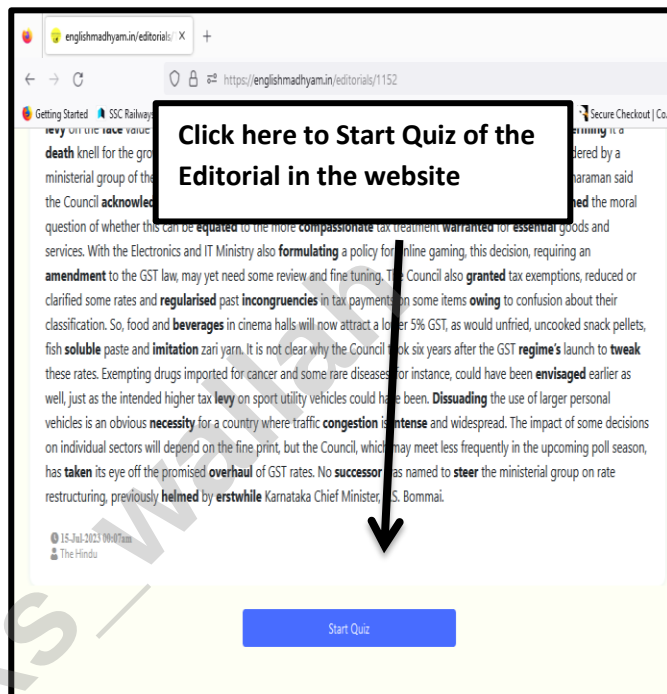
Summary of the Editorial

1. Menstrual taboos in rural India confine women to their homes, keeping them away from schools, kitchens, and religious spaces.
2. Around 335 million Indian women experience menstruation, yet most hesitate to discuss it openly.
3. Parents, especially in rural areas, lack awareness and do not discuss menstruation with their daughters.
4. The 'Red Achcha Hai' campaign is working to break menstrual taboos and raise awareness.
5. Launched in 2018 by CHETNA, the campaign focuses on body literacy, fertility, and menstrual hygiene.
6. The campaign gained urgency in 2020 after a shocking incident where hostel girls were strip-searched for menstruating.
7. The campaign expanded to Gujarat, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh using drama and visual communication to educate people.
8. The CHETNA team, dressed in red, explains menstruation, hygiene practices, and challenges myths.
9. The initiative distributed 2,199 menstrual hygiene kits with booklets, a clothes brush, a nail cutter, and a drying rope.
10. Since February 2024, the campaign has been implemented in 47 schools in Ahmedabad's Sansad block.
11. The campaign has also influenced adult women, including a sarpanch who challenged menstrual taboos by entering a temple.
12. Her actions encouraged other women to defy societal restrictions regarding menstruation.
13. Over 10,000 women and girls have been reached, inspiring more young people to join the movement.
14. Students from Riverside School in Ahmedabad raised funds to support the campaign against menstrual discrimination.
15. Poor menstrual hygiene can cause infections and increase cervical cancer risk, making awareness campaigns crucial for women's empowerment and health.

Practice Exercise: Banking Pattern Based



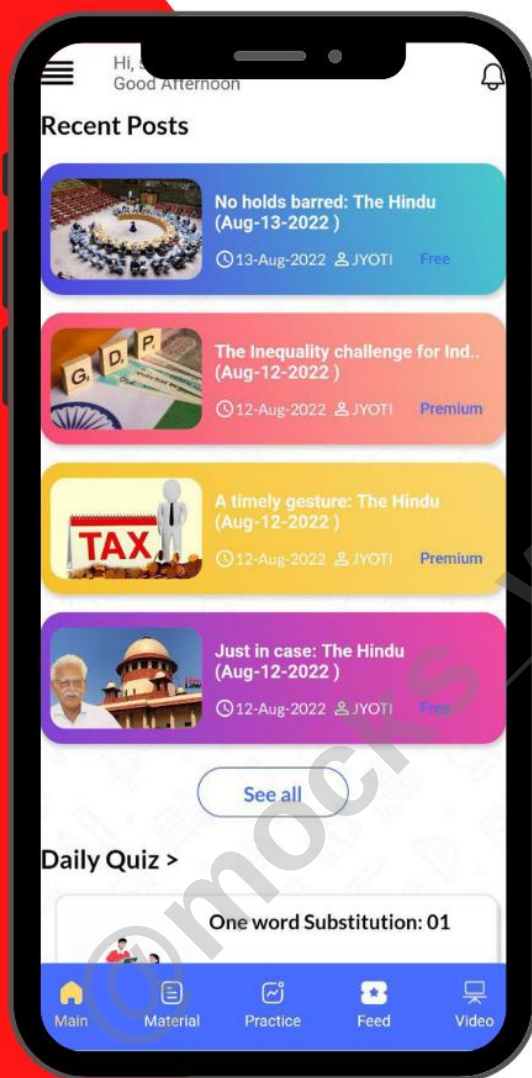
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